

Overused and Discouraged Words and Phrases

Peter Occil

This version of the document is dated 2026-07-18.

Peter Occil

To improve English usage, reduce monotony, and enrich English vocabulary in writing and speech, I have compiled these two lists on what not to say and what to say better. Many items in these tables were inspired by Emilio Bernal Labrada, “Good usage prevents abuse”, 2018.

The lists could also be useful as a handout to Literacy students from ninth grade and up, or to suggest alternatives to overused and discouraged words for younger students. For my other suggestions on Literacy instruction, see “**Suggestions for Instructional Materials**”¹.

This is an open-source document; see its **source code**². You can send comments on this document on the **GitHub issues page**³.

1 Overused Words

Instead of just saying...	Try saying...	Notes
Also, ...	in addition, furthermore, moreover, further, plus, besides, to add to that, on top of that, not only that, what is more, apart from that, additionally	
almost all a lot of people	nearly all, most all, all but a few many	Inspired by E. Bernal. See also “many people” entry.
another [number] (for example, <i>another five</i>)	[number] more, an additional [number], [number] additional, a further [number], [number] extra, an extra [number]	Inspired by E. Bernal.
award winner bad actor	awardee, recipient (of an award) wrongdoer, evildoer, baddie, malicious actor, malevolent actor, malfeasant, illegitimate actor	
bias (<i>in the sense of ‘subjective opinion’</i>) cause	prejudice, subjectivity, partiality lead to, result in, end up in, bring on, bring about, produce, yield, breed, provoke, engender, occasion, beget, give rise to	Similarly: <i>biased</i> → <i>prejudiced</i> . Verb.*

¹<https://peteroupc.github.io/insmat.html>

²<https://github.com/peteroupc/peteroupc.github.io/raw/master/usage.md>

³<https://github.com/peteroupc/peteroupc.github.io/issues>

Instead of just saying...	Try saying...	Notes
check out	discover, uncover, learn more about, find out about, see for yourself, consult	In the sense of ‘discover’, rather than ‘register a book to borrow’ or ‘end a hotel stay’.
focus on	center on, concentrate on, touch on, stress, emphasize, put/lay emphasis on, insist on, zero in on, zoom in on, prioritize, be anchored on, put/lay weight on, put/lay an accent on, deal mostly with, be about, concern, relate to, be devoted to, devote [itself] to.	
focused on (for example, <i>a book (that is) focused on a topic</i>)	about, devoted to, centered on, dealing with, treating of, relating to, involving, concentrated on, concerning, anchored on, directed to, oriented on, aimed at	
good	nice, fine, swell, decent, lovely, admirable, pleasing, pleasant	Words of positive sentiment.
great	very good, fantastic, terrific, remarkable, magnificent, excellent, splendid, wonderful, superb	Words of very positive sentiment.
happen	occur, take place, unfold, be held, come to pass, come about, manifest, produce itself, present itself.	Inspired by E. Bernal.
including [something]	[something] among them, among them [something], above all [something], [something] included, especially [something], even [something], inclusive of [something].	Inspired by E. Bernal.
leave	get out (of), step away (from), go away (from), get away (from), run away (from), walk away, exit, depart, abandon.	In the sense of ‘go away’.
<i>an event</i> leaves [someone] dead	<i>an event</i> kills [someone]; <i>an event</i> puts [someone] to death	Inspired by E. Bernal.
<i>an event</i> leaves many (people) dead	<i>an event</i> kills many; <i>an event</i> [synonym for <i>causes</i>] the death of many; <i>an event</i> puts many to death	Inspired by E. Bernal.
<i>an event</i> leaves [someone] injured	<i>an event</i> injures [someone]	Inspired by E. Bernal.
<i>an event</i> leaves many (people) injured	<i>an event</i> injures many; <i>an event</i> hurts many; <i>an event</i> [synonym for <i>causes</i>] many injuries	Inspired by E. Bernal.
little house	housie, housette, houselet, minihouse	Diminutive.
Note that...	Notably..., Notice that..., Be aware that..., Observe that..., Take note that..., It should be noted that..., It bears noting that..., It is worth noting that, It bears mentioning that..., Keep in mind that..., We point out that..., [leave out]	
keep people safe online	keep users safe online, keep Internet users safe, keep internauts safe, protect users online	

Instead of just saying...	Try saying...	Notes
jury member	juror	Suggested by E. Bernal.
many people	many	Inspired by E. Bernal.
medal winner	medalist	
member (<i>of an association, club, etc.</i>)	individual, one of [the group], adherent.	E. Bernal wrote of his concerns about this word's overuse.
people, persons	men and women, individuals, audience, public, population, anyone..., whoever..., they who..., [leave out]. <i>Informal</i> : folks.	More generally, a more specific term than <i>people</i> or <i>persons</i> is preferred. Inspired by E. Bernal.
people living in [territory]	residents of [territory], inhabitants of [territory]	Also consider, for example: <i>people living in Italy</i> → <i>Italians</i> .
(the) professors	the faculty, professorship, professor corps, professor body, body of professors	
say	state, make (it) known, mention, comment, declare, assert, express, remark. <i>Depending on context</i> : note, add, explain, affirm, elaborate, conclude; share, reveal, disclose; opine, give the opinion, argue, contend, maintain; answer, reply, respond; signal, indicate, point out; acknowledge, admit; highlight, emphasize, underline, underscore, stress.	Spanish and French press articles tend to employ numerous synonyms for this word.
sit down with	interview, join ... for an interview, meet, consult with, exchange views with, speak with, talk with, converse with, chat with	Suggested by E. Bernal.
[someone] says (that)...	According to [someone], ...In the words of [someone], ...In [someone]'s words, ...Per [someone], ...As [someone] [synonym for <i>says</i>], ...[someone] [synonym for <i>says</i>] that...	
[someone] says (that)...	In [someone]'s opinion, ...In the opinion of [someone], ...In [someone]'s view, ...In [someone]'s eyes, ...In [someone]'s estimation, ...For [someone], ...As [someone] believes, ...As [someone] sees it, ...In [someone]'s belief, ...[someone] believes that...[someone] opines that...[someone] considers that...As [someone] puts it, ...	Expressing an opinion.
[someone] says (that) [something] is...	[someone] considers [something] (as) ...[someone] labels [something] (as) ...[someone] finds [something] ...[someone] calls [something] ...[someone] pronounces [something] ...[someone] declares [something] (as) ...[someone] qualifies [something] as ...[something] is ... to [someone] for [someone], [something] is...	

Instead of just saying...	Try saying...	Notes
[someone] was identified as [name].	[someone] went by the name of [name]. [someone] was named [name]. [someone], [name], ...	Inspired by E. Bernal.
[someone], identified as [name], ...	[someone], going by the name of [name], ... [someone], named [name], ... [someone], [name], ...	Inspired by E. Bernal.
[something] is used to [do something else]	[something] serves to [do something else].	
The fact that...	That...	Suggested by Tom Hitchner, UCLA, in an Advanced Placement Daily video.
The fact that <i>he appeared</i>	That <i>he appeared</i> , <i>His appearance</i> , <i>His appearing</i> .	Suggested by Tom Hitchner, UCLA, in an Advanced Placement Daily video.
(the) teachers	teacher body, teachership, teacher corps, body of teachers	
use	employ, make use of, leverage.	Verb. Also: “ <i>something</i> is used to...” → <i>something</i> is for..., <i>something</i> serves to...; “you can use <i>something</i> to...” → with <i>something</i> you can..., <i>something</i> lets you..., <i>something</i> helps you....
what’s happening	what’s going on, what’s occurring, what’s [synonym for <i>happening</i>].	Inspired by E. Bernal.

Another technique to try is to rewrite a text to avoid overused words as much as possible.

* *Contribute to* has the variants *spur* and *fuel*, and does not mean ‘to cause’.

2 Discouraged Words

Emilio Bernal, in “Good usage prevents abuse”, wrote of his concerns about, among other things, the overuse of *people*, *persons*, *members*, *day*, and *happen*, as well as the unnecessary repetition of words (for example, *He is someone who is reliable*; *She wants what she wants*; *It’ll happen when it’ll happen*). His work formed the basis of many of the suggestions in the following table.

Don’t say...	Say...	Notes
after [something] happened, ...	after [something]	Inspired by E. Bernal.
alleged victim	likely victim	Inspired by E. Bernal.
all day today	all day [if <i>today</i> is understood], from dawn to dusk (today), from sunrise to sunset (today)	Inspired by E. Bernal.

Don't say...	Say...	Notes
basically before [something] happened, ... because of its status as because of the fact that	[leave out] before [something] for being because	Inspired by E. Bernal. Suggested by Tom Hitchner, UCLA, in an Advanced Placement Daily video. Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal.
blizzard conditions [adjective] day today (for example, <i>nice day today</i>) brand-new news by reason of its status as commission member	blizzard [adjective] day [if <i>today</i> is understood], it's [adjective] today news for being commissioner	Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal. Remark on 'member' inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal. Suggested by Tom Hitchner, UCLA, in an Advanced Placement Daily video.
dead people due to the fact that	the dead because	The word "examples" already says that the list is not all-inclusive. 'Relatives' suggested by E. Bernal.
examples include but are not limited to	examples are	Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal's note that <i>happen</i> is overused. Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal.
family members	relatives, kin	
including but not limited to individual people injured people [a meeting or show] is happening [at time, at place]	including individuals the injured ...is..., ...will be..., ...will take place..., ...will be held...	Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal's note that <i>happen</i> is overused. Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal.
is someone who is is someone who is [adjective] (for example, <i>is someone who is reliable</i>) is something that is it is midnight tonight least favorite literally (<i>in the sense of 'absolutely'</i>)	is is [adjective]; is a(n) [adjective] one is it is midnight least desired, least preferred, most hated absolutely, totally, utterly, altogether, downright, completely, certainly; [leave out]***	Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal.
moment in time most favorite myth (<i>when a story is not meant</i>) [adjective] night tonight (<i>for example: "nice night tonight"</i>) [number] people/persons	moment favorite falsehood, untruth [adjective] night (<i>if tonight is understood</i>), it's [adjective] tonight [number]	Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal. Inspired by E. Bernal. Leave out <i>people</i> or <i>persons</i> if understood. Inspired by E. Bernal.

Don't say...	Say...	Notes
one way or another	either way; [leave out]	Inspired by E. Bernal.
one way or the other	either way; [leave out]	Inspired by E. Bernal.
other people	others	Inspired by E. Bernal.
people's identities	who someone is, every personal identity	Inspired by E. Bernal.
people's lives	(human) life	Inspired by E. Bernal.
people/persons being held/jailed	(the) detainees, the jailed. <i>In criminal cases:</i> (the) inmates, the prisoners.	Inspired by E. Bernal.
people/persons know	it is known, it is generally known, it is commonly known, we know	Inspired by E. Bernal.
people/persons complaining	(the) complainants	Inspired by E. Bernal.
people/persons present/attending	(the) attendees, the audience, the attending public	Inspired by E. Bernal.
people/persons think	it is thought, it is commonly thought, it is believed, the general belief is, we think, they believe, by popular belief	Inspired by E. Bernal.
point in time	time, instant, moment	Inspired by E. Bernal.
pregnant people	the pregnant, pregnant women	
prevent [something] from happening	prevent [something]	Inspired by E. Bernal.
rain conditions, rainy conditions	rain. <i>Or as appropriate:</i> drizzle, showers, squalls, light rain, heavy rain, downpours.	Inspired by E. Bernal.
remove (<i>in the sense of 'erase' or 'abolish'</i>)	take out, take away, do away with, eliminate, erase, delete, suppress, withhold, get [something] off, get rid of, abolish, repeal, rescind	It is correct to say "remove [something] from [something else]", speak of "removing" an obstacle or disadvantage, or use in the sense of 'move [something] away'.
(they) saved their lives	(they) were saved, (they) saved their life	Inspired by E. Bernal.
(their) lives, deaths, lifetimes, healths, sakes, identities, futures	their life, death, lifetime, health, sake, identity, future	Inspired by E. Bernal.
This is [program].	<i>To identify the program:</i> [program]; You are listening to [program]; You are tuned to [program]. <i>To present the program:</i> [program] starts now; We (now) welcome you to [program]; We (now) bring you [program]; Now starting [program]; Presenting [program]; We now present [program]; We now start [program]; It's time for [program].	Identifications of TV and radio programs. Suggested by E. Bernal.
[time] before now	[time] ago	Inspired by E. Bernal.
until such time as	until	
up to but not more than	up to	
[verb] whether or not (for example, <i>know whether or not,</i> <i>determine whether or not</i>)	[verb] whether**	Suggested by E. Bernal.

Even here, it is worth trying to rewrite a text to avoid discouraged words to the greatest extent possible.

** Use "whether or not B" or "whether B or not" only to mean 'both if B and if not'.

*** In formal writing, use *literally* only to mean ‘in the exact sense; not figuratively’.

3 To Improve English Usage Through Word Processing Apps...

What I would like to see is an open-source plugin for popular word-processing applications that finds overused and discouraged words and phrases in a document, such as those mentioned earlier, and suggests corresponding replacements. (A similar practice is found in Web browsers’ spell checkers and as a built-in feature in some closed source word-processing apps.) For example, the plugin could look for instances of “sit down with”, underline them, and show suggestions such as “interview”, “consult with”, and so on in a menu when the phrase is selected for a language check.

4 Derivations

Derivations of existing words, so underused a procedure in our language, can enrich the vocabulary of English.

An interesting exercise to try with students is to build—

- the feminine form of some words through suffixes. For example, -an becomes -anesse, -ian becomes -ienne, -ican becomes -ickenne or -icanesse: *Bostonian* becomes *Bostonienne*, *American* becomes *Americkenne* or *Americanesse*, *Puerto Rican* becomes *Puerto Ricanesse* etc., instead of resorting to adding *female* or *woman*.
- the diminutive form of some words through suffixes (for example: -ie, -ette, -kin, -let) or through prefixes (for example: mini-, micro-), without resorting to adding *little* or *small*.

5 License

Any copyright to this page is released to the Public Domain. In case this is not possible, this page is also licensed under **Creative Commons Zero**⁴.

⁴<https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/>